

(En)tangled Ethics and Relational Mobilities: Reflections on Decolonial Feminist Digital Participatory Action Research

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Abstract

This paper explores the ethical entanglements and tensions that arise when using a decolonial feminist approach to digital participatory action research (DPAR) within the context of bicycling, mobility(ies), and gender justice in rural Nicaragua. Grounded in a reflexive feminist ethics of care and relational mobilities, I reflect on a collaborative DPAR project with co-researchers that aimed to address the intertwined issues of mobility justice, sexual and gender-based violence (SGBV) and climate change. Through digital methods – such as photovoice and participatory GIS mapping using GoPro cameras – co-researchers mapped specific community spaces marked by SGBV and environmental precarity, revealing the layered dynamics of gendered, racialized and ecological injustice that shaped their everyday mobilities. Drawing on these experiences, I offer critical reflections on the possibilities and tensions of decolonial feminist DPAR, including (1) the necessity of a feminist reflexive ethics of care; and (2) the ethical entanglements involved in using technological interventions that may inadvertently reproduce structural inequalities. While digital technologies may pry open opportunities for collective storytelling and community advocacy, I contend that their use must be guided by ongoing ethical considerations to ensure that relational mobilities and accountabilities – and the voices of co-researchers in DPAR projects – remain central.

Keywords

decolonial feminism, digital participatory action research, mobility justice, bicycles, sexual and gender-based violence, Nicaragua

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Introduction

Participatory action research (PAR) centres on the idea that social inquiry projects should involve the active participation of marginalized groups, aiming to ground the research in ethics and responsibility while exposing and addressing social injustice (Reid & Frisby, 2008). Foregrounding the *participatory* thus requires research team members to critically examine *who is* and *who is not* involved in each project. However, and as recent PAR scholarship has pointed out, applying a decolonial feminist lens to PAR amplifies such concerns around participation and grounds them more squarely in unequal power dynamics (Lenette, 2022). Put differently, and as I argue throughout this paper, a *digital* decolonial feminist approach strives to go beyond “traditional” PAR studies by actively reconfiguring knowledge production processes that have historically overlooked and excluded marginalized communities.

In recent years PAR methods have gained traction, particularly as social scientists and communities seek innovative, community-driven approaches to understand and address the profound impacts and significant social and economic inequities revealed by the pandemic (Auerbach et al., 2022). Indeed, qualitative researchers have creatively investigated how more participatory forms of research may drive new possibilities and approaches that shift participants as “co-producers of knowledge and potentially as co-researchers” (Gubrium & Harper, 2016, p. 13). Here, I use the term *co-researcher* to refer to “people with lived experiences who are active agents in the co-production (co-design or co-creation) of new knowledge as a core characteristic of PAR” (Lenette, 2022, p. 2). *Co-researcher models thus uphold and heighten collaborative relations between co-researchers and (academic) researchers to reconfigure and address unequal power relations; ensuring more relationally imbued, ethically grounded, socially just approaches to knowledge exchange that reflect a moral commitment to collaborative and participatory research processes* (Lenette, 2022).

The objective of this paper is to explore the power dynamics, challenges, tensions, benefits and insights exposed by applying a decolonial feminist approach to digital participatory action research (DPAR) through a project in Nicaragua with co-researchers. Since 2014, this project has used a DPAR approach to critically examine intersections of gender, sport, ‘development’, and mobility justice. Like others who have written about the epistemological, social, and ethical pairing of decolonial methodologies with PAR (e.g., Gill et al., 2012), I acknowledge the essential contributions of my co-researchers and communities involved in the research I discuss herein. At the same time, I recognize the stark and uncomfortable tensions involved in using decolonial feminist approaches, which call for to decentering the researcher’s authority – in conjunction with reflexive first-person narration, which simultaneously re-centers the researcher in the analysis.¹ Indeed, I chose to write this manuscript using my “personal voic[e]/narrative[e] and subjective standpoint[t] in the process of decolonizing monolithic dominant academic writing” (Gill et al., 2012, p. 1). As Friedman et al. (2018, p. 5) rightfully note, “there is a big difference between researchers ‘working with’ participants and becoming co-researchers with participants.” I attempt to (vulnerably) confront these complexities throughout this paper in the hopes of demonstrating how the decolonial feminist methodology at hand (dis)connected to DPAR practice.

(this speaks to a tension I similarly identified in Becerra (2016) and my own work in the Fourth World

epistemic justice
is a clear
recurring theme
for what
constitutes
decolonial
research
practices

In this paper, I seek to (1) highlight the challenges and benefits of a decolonial feminist DPAR approach; (2) emphasize the importance of a reflexive feminist ethics and duties of care in navigating the “messy spaces” and unequal power dynamics inherent in a DPAR approach; and (3) discuss the advantages of using DPAR as a creative methodological contribution for engaging self-identified young women in rural Nicaragua to address the interconnected crises of climate change and sexual and gender-based violence (SGBV) in their communities.

Decolonial Feminist Research

“The future of our earth may depend upon the ability of all women to identify and develop new definitions of power and new patterns of relations across difference (Lorde, 2007, p. 123).

Lorde’s statement serves as a cornerstone for reimagining the possibilities of creating bold coalitions across differences that advocate for socially just futurities for all women. In line with Lorde’s imperative to “develop new definitions of power,” Bradbury (2023, p. 1, *italics added*), echoes this sentiment by emphasizing that “action researchers can’t really help transformations happen in contexts of intractable problems if we are not, slowly but surely, *introducing new ways of working with power*.”

However, in the context of decolonization, engaging with power becomes even more pressing. Tuck and Yang (2012, p. 21) articulate this urgency by defining decolonization as “the repatriation of Indigenous land and life,” further imploring that “decolonization is not a metonym for social justice.” They further that employing a decolonial lens has been critiqued as a way for settlers to “mov[e] to innocence” (Tuck & Yang, 2012, p. 35). My hope herein is not to flatten or overuse “decolonization,” but rather to approach this work from a more relational, land-and life-based perspective to foreground interdependence, social systems, and uphold an ongoing commitment to refusing complicity (Land Justice Futures, 2025). A decolonial practice thus strives to actively disrupt cycles of harm and challenge the superficial use of “decolonization.” It means recognizing my positionality as a white, cisgender settler and committing to engage with this work with solidarity, accountability, transformative justice, and purpose.²

7 important reminder of how decolonizing practice is active & driven towards material change

Importantly, Curiel (2022, p. 56) contends that a decolonial feminist approach “seeks to do research and to make methodological and pedagogical proposals from collective processes and from organizations and communities to strengthen their own analytical frameworks that lead to better ways to search for social transformation.” The emphasis on collective, community-driven transformation resonates with the principles of antiracist feminism, which also seeks to challenge and dismantle the colonial systems of power and knowledge that have historically marginalized and ‘blanked’ oppressed women, people of colour, and other disadvantaged groups (Lugones, 2010).

again, highlighting this as an active practice

In calling for a decolonial feminist DPAR approach, I would be remiss not to highlight that “the rhetoric of decolonizing feminism has established the site of the decolonial as sometimes ambiguous, uncritically calling for Global South alliances *without recognising the geopolitical power from where such scholars and students stand*” (Persard, 2021, p. 128; *emphasis added*). For example – and as I elaborate in the sections that follow – the

current geopolitical context in Nicaragua has complicated the building of solidarities and alliances in the research discussed herein.

Decolonial Feminist Digital Participatory Action Research (DPAR)

In this paper, I aim to contribute new insights to PAR by extending visual methods through DPAR, grounded in a decolonial feminist approach. I do so in an effort to try and better engage with the multiple ways of knowing and make (even a small) methodological contribution.

Digital qualitative research is defined as research that includes: (1) digital content as a source of or representation of data, such as digitized texts, images or videos, (2) digital contexts, such as online networks as research sites, and (3) digital practices such as interactions and engagements between social actors mediated or facilitated by technology (Goodyear & Bundon, 2021, p. 2).

Various digital research tools have been taken up through feminist methods in a variety of ways, such as digital mapping and digital street harassment activism through social media accounts (e.g., Fileborn & Trott, 2022; Hayhurst et al., 2025a). More specifically, DPAR has become increasingly prevalent in better understanding the sociological significance of digital devices and wearable cameras (Rick & Bustad, 2021).

DPAR builds on digital qualitative research but refers more specifically to *participatory research methods* that involve the active involvement of — and collaboration with — co-researchers in the design, data collection, analysis, and dissemination of research findings using *digital technologies, content, contexts and/or practices*. Part of the draw to decolonial feminist approaches to DPAR pertains to (1) its unique possibilities for innovative collaborations with co-researchers to co-create *multiple knowledges* using digital mediums to heighten collective responses to lived experiences of injustice; and (2) its creative opportunities to transform power as it festers in systems such as global neoliberal capitalism, colonialism, patriarchy, and racism. In my work with co-researchers in this project, decolonial feminist DPAR has emphasized the visceralities of — for example — environmental degradation, SGBV, and (im)mobilities.

Methodology

This study was part of a larger research project that focused on gender, mobility justice, bicycles and “development” in three countries: Nicaragua, Canada, and Uganda. In this paper, I focus on research from a DPAR project in two communities in the southern part of Nicaragua. The communities are both rural, focused primarily on agricultural activities for income generation.

Understanding the historical context of these locales is crucial, as Spanish colonization continues to profoundly shape these communities. Spanish colonialism began in Nicaragua in 1522 with the arrival of conquistador Gil González de Ávila (Disney, 2008). Over the next three centuries, colonization was marked by corruption, Christianization, and military aggression. This period saw the decimation of Indigenous populations and the

exploitative encomienda system, where Indigenous labor was forcibly utilized (Disney, 2008). The legacy of these colonial divisions persists today.

Nicaragua currently faces high levels of poverty that have been declining since the early 2000s, but that continue to escalate following the 2018 socio-political tensions and the onset of COVID-19 (Neumann, 2023). It is one of the most vulnerable nations to the impacts of climate change, ranking 49th on the GCRI from 2000 – 2019 (Eckstein et al., 2021). In Nicaragua, one in three women have experienced some form of SGBV (Neumann, 2023).

Since 2014, I have been collaborating with a non-governmental organization (NGO), which I will refer to herein as ‘Pedal Power’ to protect their organizational identity. At that time, I was introduced to Pedal Power through a former research project with one of their international partners – an organization that operates out of Western Europe and provides organizations with the resources they need to amplify girls’ and women’s voices to uphold their rights through sport and economic resilience. Our relationship has continued to evolve over the last decade, organically underpinned by our mutually prioritized interests on gender, mobility justice, sport and digital participatory research methodologies. Pedal Power is primarily made up of local volunteers and paid part-time staff, and it has been operating in a range of communities in rural southern Nicaragua, but we focused our research on the two communities it works with most closely. Founded in 1994, the central goal of Pedal Power is to empower Nicaraguan youth through several programs and interventions related to sport, youth leadership, and gender equality. Pedal Power focuses on ‘empowering’ young women through fútbol curriculum and workshops centred on sexual and reproductive health rights, SGBV, and climate justice. Pedal Power started to use bicycling the year it was founded, alongside their fútbol program, as an advocacy tool to coalesce around certain causes they supported.

Pedal Power introduced us to the co-researchers involved in the project, who were 16 self-identified women (including cis, trans as well as non-binary people) between the ages of 18 and 30 and who were in high school or university and/or worked primarily in agriculture businesses selling food or other products in their communities. Below, I outline the data collection activities conducted as part of our decolonial feminist DPAR approach. Table 1 presents an overview of the team’s research activities.

In accordance with the ethical guidelines outlined by my institution’s ORE, pseudonyms have been used to protect the identities of all the organizations and participants involved in this research. I have also deliberately evaded contextual information to do my best to safeguard their privacy.

Researcher Social Location

Reflexivity, social location, insider/outsider status and critical self-inquiry play an essential role in the research and evaluation process of FPAR (Reid & Frisby, 2008). Decolonial feminist approaches also call for locating the researcher, recognizing how our own identities and institutional affiliations shape knowledge production, while upholding relational accountability (Lenette, 2022). In conducting this study, I made a concerted effort to remain responsive to my own social identity and maintain a self-reflexive approach throughout the research process and data collection. This included being hyper-reflexive as to the multiple and overlapping ways that my ancestral background, sexual

I wonder what the implications are for this particular organizational model and how that shapes the research context and process?

Table 1. Overview of Research Activities and Participants

Activity	Data collection method	Participants
Digital PAR workshop with GoPros	n/a	16 co-researchers (young Nicaraguan women)
Photovoice and short video activities with GPS-enabled GoPro cameras	Semi-structured interviews, including separate photovoice/video interviews about their images/ videos.	16 co-researchers (young Nicaraguan women)
Photocollages on poster boards using print outs of photos, art supplies, objects from nature glued to poster	Analyzing posters across participants to discuss key themes generated.	16 co-researchers (young Nicaraguan women)
Sketch mapping activities	Participants used predetermined shapes and colours to represent their feelings and experiences with place (green, yellow and red crosses with assigned meanings) but had the option to draw their own localized maps and choose where these crosses were drawn and arranged on the page.	16 co-researchers (young Nicaraguan women)

and gender identity including – identifying as a Canadian (with English, Scottish and Irish ancestry), cisgender and heterosexual woman – shaped the research process, outcomes, products and dissemination. I speak English and was mostly educated on the traditional territory of the Haudenosaunee and Anishinaabe (Ontario, Canada). My decade of fieldwork using digital FPAR with survivors of various forms of violence and my personal experiences with SGBV shaped the research focus on interconnected webs of violence. In the sections that follow, I (try to) openly engage with a reflexive decolonial feminist ethics in navigating these very power dynamics inherent in DPAR.

Overview of DPAR Methods

Photovoice

Using photovoice helped us to better understand the key enablers and barriers to cycling through the eyes of the co-researchers. In the previous decade of research with Pedal Power, staff and co-researchers had successfully used digital storytelling alongside photovoice (see [Hayhurst & del Socorro Cruz Centeno, 2019](#)). Pedal Power used these films to leverage external funding for their work, and the co-researchers and staff had discussed creating a (now completed) documentary film for the next iteration of research.

In light of the shared objective of making a (now completed) documentary film, we used GoPro cameras because they are small, durable, could be mounted on co-researchers' bicycles to record both photos and video footage while riding, and were GPS enabled to

Multiple uses for this data, including research/analysis as well as developing materials to meet the organization's goals and show the efficacy of their work

assist with participatory mapping activities. There were eight cameras, and each camera was shared between two participants from the same community, for a total of eight groups (16 participants). Co-researchers were responsible for ensuring the cameras were shared based on a mutually agreed upon schedule. After the initial orientation and camera use workshop, the participants were given one week to record short videos and take photos.

The co-researchers used the digital videos and photos to present their bicycling experiences. During the period of photo taking, I alternated between communities each day and conducted semi-structured interviews with the co-researchers, with the support of a research assistant (RA) and translator. Each interview consisted of discussing 2-3 photos and 1-2 videos of the photographers' choosing and lasted for around 20 minutes. A translator well-versed in the local Spanish dialect in these communities, and with whom I have partnered throughout the last ten years with Pedal Power, assisted with the interviews. Hereafter, I conducted interviews with each co-researcher, during which they shared their recorded videos and photos in relation to (1) where the video/photo was taken and (2) what the image/footage meant to them. Co-researchers were then asked to explain two of their "best photos/videos" among their collection in relation to key barriers/enablers to their participation in Pedal Power's bicycle-focused program. Next, co-researchers took part in a semi-structured interview focused on a range of topics, including (for example) sharing key information about themselves and their lives, and their understandings as to how bicycles impact community life.

With the rise of digital cameras, photovoice as a DPAR method has become more prevalent, offering a unique way in which the perspectives of community participants are digitized, prioritized, and then repurposed as stimulants in group discussions (Rick & Bustad, 2021). At the same time, digital photovoice approaches risk reinforcing power imbalances between researcher and co-researchers. Issues such as community stigmatization of (digital) camera users, concerns about surveillance and decreased anonymity for participants, and heightened visibility for those in precarious situations often arise (Borish et al., 2021). It was critical, then, to understand these risks and take any actions possible to minimize the potential harm to participants.

Photo Collages

Following the interviews, all 16 co-researchers co-created photo collages on poster boards using their printed photos, markers, art materials, and objects from nature of their choosing (e.g., twigs, rocks, etc.), and added text captions and any other materials they felt were important for expressing their experiences with bicycling in their communities. As Angelica, one co-researcher submitted, the hope was that these photo collages would reach those decision-makers who might then facilitate safer bicycling conditions (e.g., more lights on roads). Finally, after one week, I (along with a RA and translator) came together with co-researchers in each of the two communities to engage in dialogue centred on what they wanted to relay to key decision-makers about their bicycling experiences.

Participatory Mapping

A key overall goal of this research was to underline the importance of community-specific barriers and facilitators to mobility for the young women by using participatory mapping,

geographic information systems (GIS) and **critical socio-spatial methods**. The aim was to concurrently address community-identified barriers to mobility and develop advocacy tools (e.g., story maps and a documentary film) for Pedal Power to address unsafe cycling spaces and access to cycling for their participants and other community members.

Socio-spatial methods and GIS are being increasingly recognized as legitimate tools to better understand the contextual elements related to community health profiling, health access and planning. Contextual elements are widely understood as being a key determinant for mobility, with those living in marginalizing neighbourhood conditions being associated with lower mobility levels and higher rates of SGBV (Hayhurst et al., 2025a; Sheppard-Perkins et al., 2024).

Sketch Maps

Sketch maps are widely used in participatory socio-spatial methods and GIS research as an accessible way for participants to represent their lived experiences on paper maps, later used to develop GIS (Denwood et al., 2023). This approach attempts to capture the relationships between people and their environments using a blank sheet of paper or printed map marked with relevant information (Curtis, 2012). Our research used pre-determined shapes and colours to represent feelings and experiences while allowing participants to draw localized maps and arrange the symbols as they chose (Denwood et al., 2023).

Data Analysis

The initial analysis of the data began while in the field with daily memos and discussions happening between members of the research team and was followed by a deeper investigation when our research team was back in Canada. Data was initially collected in Spanish, with interviews being facilitated by an experienced local translator we have worked with for the last decade. The interviews were then transcribed, and the data was analyzed along with the accompanying photos, poster collages, and sketch maps using Nvivo 10. We then shared initial findings with community partners via Zoom to ensure key findings reflected their experiences.

Tensions and Challenges in Decolonial Feminist DPAR

Feminist Reflexive Ethics of Care

Feminist reflexive ethics is a strategy of resistance that “has transformational potential for a field designed to investigate and challenge processes of power, especially those processes that create and sustain embodied vulnerability” (Durham, 2024, p. 9). My goal was to uphold just social structures and share knowledge while prioritizing the voices of the local communities in co-creating (for example) meaningful and sustainable solutions that address SGBV and climate-related challenges.

As noted, applying Western conventions and approaches of knowledge production within non-Western research contexts is fraught with tensions and complexities. In their

PAR work using preventative digital tools to support young women experiencing intimate partner violence, Thomas-Hughes (2018, p. 233) used the concept “messy places” to help explain tensions pertaining to obligation and power, consent, data storage, and anonymization and privacy, suggesting that “mess is a permanent feature of participatory research methodologies and should be acknowledged and discussed rather than ignored or suppressed.” However, dominant colonial cultures often impose expectations of perfection, and it is important to honour non-linear, emergent ways of working as ones that may be a form of resistance to colonial logics, especially in community-engaged, decolonial research contexts.³ Indeed, a decolonial feminist reflexive ethics – and praxis – amplifies the concerns brought to bear by Thomas-Hughes by blatantly probing the (neo-) colonial dynamics of knowledge extraction and production. Such an ethics is marked by scholarship that is deeply committed to acknowledging positionality in relation to co-researchers within broader global power inequalities.

Despite the potential for DPAR to elicit essential insights into participants’ experiences, ethical issues arose in the work herein that led to capricious tensions with this approach. First, when not driven by a decolonial feminist ethic, digital technologies such as the GoPro may be potentially limited in their ability to only *partially* convey and encapsulate lived experience (Rick & Bustad, 2021). For example, Angelica explained the challenge of trying to share the road conditions through a short GoPro video she filmed on her bike:

I wanted to show you the road conditions, that even though this is a bad road, I use my bicycle. I wanted to show the road conditions. The road, even though it’s not – it’s a bad road, it doesn’t impede me to go to school. It doesn’t become an obstacle to – for me to go to school.

(highlighting inadequacies of this technology to capture the full complexity of the data)

Several participants shared photos and videos of the non-human to draw attention to the specific environmental destruction they experienced (e.g., pools of water left after hurricanes obstructing their routes) that impeded their bicycling journeys and resulted in violent environmental conditions. As Ambar explained after sharing GoPro footage from her cycling journey across an overflowing river (Image 1):

When that river is filled, then it becomes a pretty sight that is also at the same time an area that is very dangerous to cross. There is a bridge. If the bridge by any reason fails or falls, there will be no passages. When it rains, the current will carry a lot of rocks ...The river is always overflowing.

While a DPAR approach drew attention to these non-human factors, at the same time, I (along with Pedal Power staff) did not want to risk the privacy and safety of the co-researchers by sharing their regular riding patterns with others who could use this information to contribute to their feelings of unease. That is, by highlighting the non-human barriers through the digital, visual, and participatory mapping, this DPAR approach risked amplifying recognizable spaces where violence occurred – not just environmental, but also SGBV (explained further below) – paradoxically reinforcing local community understandings of where there were opportunities to further perpetuate such violence (Image 2).

(an example of tensions / risks associated with what we render visible in research)



Image 1. Angelica's Photo of Rugged Road Conditions

Nonetheless, the digital data vis-à-vis the GoPros heightened the transformative possibilities and ways that co-researchers were able to survive oppressive and environmentally damaged areas and violent spaces and challenge perceptions of vulnerability. Again, through interviews with co-researchers and through participatory mapping activities using their GoPro cameras, their experiences of harassment and violence while biking were chronicled, especially while navigating isolated “risky” spaces outside of their homes and town centres. These spaces were remote and set along roads that cut through the jungle, often located between towns where there were no residential dwellings, and where men often congregated to drink alcohol and to fish. As Ambar recalled:

There are some areas on the road where there's no houses at all or perhaps places where there might be men working. I try to avoid those places because they might say things to you or might do things. I am fearful that they might cause me some harm, so I'd rather not travel alone if I have to go [to] those places.

Co-researchers pointed to the regular harassment that they would face when passing through these areas, with verbal assaults occurring frequently. Their visceralities of violence incisively pointed to their shared struggles with heteropatriarchal systems, evidenced through images and videos of rock throwing, stalking, and unwanted encounters that would cause them to fear for their safety and physical, emotional, and mental well-being (Image 3).

I sat with the uncomfortable “messy places” and did my best to use a feminist ethics of care as a moral compass to foreground decolonial feminist methodological learning, disruption, and change, which I further discuss in the next section.



Image 2. Ambar's Shot of the Overflowing River's Dangers

SGBV in "Risky" Spaces

Recent digital technologies have recast the value of using research as a tool for activism in the realm of SGBV. That is, the use of digital technologies (such as GoPros) do not "reconfigure the political conditions they respond to – [e.g.,] ... structural sexism and racism – they subsequently are also tied to capitalism, surveillance, and carceral logics of safety" (Banet-Weiser & Higgins, 2023, p. 96). While my goal in using the GoPros was to better support the advocacy efforts of co-researchers in mapping and reporting instances of SGBV to key decision-makers, ironically, these decision-makers (i.e., the state) are often the ones that "resist believing women in the first place" (Banet-Weiser & Higgins, 2023, p. 104).

Co-researchers highlighted the regular harassment that they would face when passing through areas (many marked on their sketch maps), with verbal assaults and "catcalling" occurring frequently. Several co-researchers mentioned that while they wanted to attend classes, their parents did not want them attending high school because of the need to pass through these isolated spaces and the potential risks posed to them during their journey.

Even though actual physical attacks or verbal harassment did not occur every time a co-researcher was cycling, the past experiences of SGBV that took place in these areas led to feelings of trepidation when they travelled in these spaces. Indeed, there is only a single road that circles the communities involved in Pedal Power and connects the young women to school, stores, and medical centres. Maria explained these challenges:

I was coming from [name of town] which is the place where the school is located. I was riding by myself. There are some areas that are very isolated, a road that is very isolated. I was feeling that perhaps somebody was following me or that they might want to harm me. That sense, that feeling – I don't feel that it's safe if I'm all by myself.



Image 3. Amber's Photo of an Isolated Road

And yet, at the same time, co-researchers explained how cycling helped bring them joy, pleasure, freedom, and opportunities to find “peaceful place[s],” as the bikes were viewed to bypass the risky areas more quickly and fostered a sense of empowerment through enhanced mobility. Haru further explained how, by riding her bicycle, she was able to challenge gender norms and feel more confident:

Riding a bicycle makes me feel healthier. I have a higher resistance to many, many of the boys that are at school. Usually, it has been very helpful because I exercise my legs by using the bicycle. I have more strength.

Like Haru, the experiences co-researchers shared pointed to an acute juxtaposition of empowerment and vulnerability. In some ways, such frictions echo what [Meer and Müller \(2023\)](#) describe as the “tensions inherent in decolonial praxis,” where participatory projects can simultaneously disrupt and reinforce systemic inequities. That is, co-researchers spoke of how their bicycles represented both a means of mobility and resistance to gender norms. Their bicycles served as a stark reminder of the dangers posed by colonial and patriarchal systems of surveillance and control that shape public spaces. And yet, this duality reflects the broader complexities highlighted by our decolonial DPAR approach, because digital data-driven methods cannot be disentangled from their socio-cultural, racialized, and gendered contexts ([Leurs, 2017](#)). [Leurs’ \(2017\)](#) framework on “ethics of care” for feminist data studies underscores the need to approach technologies like GoPros as inherently embedded in power hierarchies that shape what kinds of data are valued and whose voices are amplified. In a similar vein, this mirrors lessons from the ‘Making All Voices Count’ initiative, which highlighted the necessity of embedding technological innovations in deeply contextualized understandings of governance and power structures, rather than treating technology as inherently transformative (see [Edwards et al., 2018](#)).

In turn, a key concern with using GoPros and decolonial feminist DPAR strategies is that they may contradict feminist ethics of care by promoting a “method of witnessing” and placing responsibility on victims for their reported or visually captured experiences (Banet-Weiser & Higgins, 2023, p. 107). That is, the visual documentation of the spaces and places where our co-researchers felt unsafe, or where they had experienced SGBV, end up “furnish[ing] forms of evidence that, though they may support the facticity of events, cannot meaningfully support the facticity of *harms*” (Banet-Weiser & Higgins, 2023, p. 107; emphasis added).

Meer and Müller’s (2023) critique of participatory and creative methods highlight the messy tensions between amplifying marginalized voices and the risk of reproducing the very systems of coloniality they aim to disrupt. Indeed, their concept of “epistemic authority” cautions against positioning digital outputs as more valid than lived experiences, emphasizing the need for context-specific reflexivity and equitable redistribution of power within research practices. Drawing from Maldonado-Torres’ (2007) concept of coloniality, the authors suggest that participatory projects can unintentionally reinforce epistemic hierarchies (Meer & Müller, 2023). These issues were at the core of a desire for a deeper reflection within the project on how the GoPro data was framed and utilized, leading to six virtual meetings from December 2022 – March 2024 with co-researchers to collaboratively decide on strategies that prioritized their voices and agency. By situating the GoPro footage as a supplementary tool rather than the central narrative, the project attempted to challenge the primacy of state-sanctioned ‘evidence,’ though such efforts remained fraught with challenges, as underlined by Leurs’ (2017) call for alternative analytics that prioritize embodied experiences.

Although both the Pedal Power staff and I aspired, as ‘feminist PAR activists’ to use visual mediums and the GPS-enabled technologies to enhance co-researchers’ safety; we also worried that our DPAR approaches could not disrupt and upend SGBV as a structuring system that reinforced and perpetuated gender inequalities. Such issues were further evident in the photovoice interview below, with Estefani:

Estefani: I will be fearful if I go to places that are very alone [...] when you’re bicycling to [location] there are certain places that are very alone. There are not many people there or there are no people there. But when you go to school and you are by yourself, perhaps people get ahead and then you’re left all by yourself on the road to [location]. So that could be a little scary [...] They can grab me there if I’m by myself. You might encounter groups of men that are drinking or that might be drunk.

LH: So at that specific location there are usually men drinking?

Estefani: Yeah, there are men drinking on the road [points to the road on the image].

I share the excerpt above to try and show how I *attempted* to use GoPros in the name of advocacy and “better protection” in solidarity with co-researchers to ensure they had informed understandings of how to move through the public spaces in their communities, which of course, is unquestionably important. And yet, trying to document the precise locations where co-researchers felt unsafe did not blatantly challenge the very racialized, gendered, and classed visual and geospatial logics of SGBV in and of itself (Image 4).



Image 4. Estefani's Photo of a Deserted Road She Travelled Regularly

To be clear, following data collection, I (with the RA and translator) held six virtual meetings with co-researchers to discuss how to best use the GIS data to better contribute to feminist activisms. Pedal Power staff, and co-researchers, expressed their desire to use this data to disrupt prevailing power relations when it came to key decisions about safety, cycling infrastructure, and transportation policy in their communities. For example, during a meeting with community advisory board members (young women) following data collection (May 26, 2023), Alessia conveyed that, “the roads are being improved in the area so this is a good time for the discussions here, they [the government] put in a retention wall to stop the lake coming into the road, somewhat unexpected. A new office of national resources is now directing finances especially with politicians and family members coming to [community].”

However, I grappled with contradictions: I worried that the use of digital research contributed to the circulation of “digital evidence” that is already deeply entrenched in (re) producing the gendered and raced myths that undergird contemporary cultures of SGBV (Banet-Weiser & Higgins, 2023). Simply put, although my use of decolonial feminist DPAR and the use of GPS-enabled GoPros more specifically was optimistically developed in relation with our co-researchers “in the name of safety,” I was struck by my own contradictory contributions to the “digitization of doubt” (see Banet-Weiser & Higgins, 2023).

Building on insights from the ‘Making All Voices Count’ initiative, the virtual meetings with co-researchers – as described above – frequently emphasized the need for technologies that do not merely “capture” but actively “amplify” silenced voices in ways that challenge entrenched power dynamics (Edwards et al., 2018). Co-researchers described how the GPS-enabled maps helped articulate their safety concerns to local decision-makers, enabling improvements such as newly paved roads. Specifically, as Alessia further noted:

this so deeply resonates with my experience with Raleigh city council not fully grasping the scale of the fourth ward's destruction until I began digitizing their records, despite countless residents testifying to their lived experiences over the years

It was really helpful for them [the girls] having resources and media [from GoPros] to share with municipality, other allies, other groups, to show that the girls are able to use this to improve their livelihoods, lives, empowerment, and the girls are able to engage in conversations around this and how it can improve not only their own lives but also the community.

And yet, these conversations also revealed how technological interventions may expose the risks and hardships girls face but ultimately fail to dismantle the structural inequalities (e.g., gendered mobility constraints) that sustain SGBV and limit communities' ability to act on the very injustices these tools capture. For example, as Hary conjured:

We really would like your support to...sometimes the group will need maintenance of the bicycles. That we will need some type of support for the maintenance of the bicycle, to be able to repair the bicycles...I was looking at the video of the kids, I feel so sad. Because even though they're always walking alone, it's not safe and it is a long distance. I wish I could help them. I am unable to. I don't have the means.

In fact, these very tensions may connect to the limitations of what [Leurs \(2017\)](#) terms the “data-rush mentality,” where technologies are deployed with little attention to their implications for intersectional power relations. Such concerns pertain to mobility data justice, which, as [Behrendt and Sheller \(2024, p. 164\)](#) contend, explores “critical perspectives on how data is being gathered, organized and utilized in ways that shape social and spatial organization including mobilities.” So how, then, was I possibly complicit in this very act of commodification and mobility data (in)justice – issues that hinge on the very idea that “women’s own stories are not good enough” and unbelievable on their own?

Together with Pedal Power staff and co-researchers, there was hope that GoPro footage would help influence local decision-makers to improve infrastructure and safety based on community-identified needs. As Alessia noted, some infrastructure has changed since the research took place. However, participatory mapping and digital methods like GoPro recordings were intended primarily as advocacy tools to foreground community-specific issues – not to guarantee policy change. While co-researchers *did* utilize these tools to communicate their concerns to decision-makers, I hesitate to claim a causal link between our project and any positive infrastructural changes. But the challenge was that this data became a form of “evidence” that could be perceived by these decision-makers as superior to women’s testimonies ([Banet-Weiser & Higgins, 2023, p. 99](#)). This raises an important question: why weren’t the co-researchers’ accounts of their lived experiences considered credible on their own?

Concluding Reflections

This paper argues that digital, decolonial feminist approaches deepen PAR by producing meaningful findings in collaboration with marginalized co-researchers, particularly in the context of bicycling safety, mobility, and justice. By centering the voices and experiences of co-researchers, I contend that DPAR holds promising possibilities to uphold intersectional justice and transformative solidarity.

Nonetheless, this study also revealed critical challenges and uncomfortable truths at play in ensuring that decolonial feminist DPAR more effectively advances social justice and transformative goals (see Hayhurst et al., 2025c). While there is no monolithic ‘playbook’ that reveals how researchers might navigate these tensions and contradictions, there are some key learnings that I humbly share with cautious optimism. First, a feminist ethics of care, embodied research ethic and “radical vulnerability” imbued with trust, mutuality, relationality and reciprocity are essential for emphasizing human dignity, inclusivity, and community in using decolonial feminist DPAR approaches. Nagar (2014, p. 12), for example, explains how committing to “cultivat[ing] a radical vulnerability through situated solidarities” means that we must “grapple with the material and symbolic politics of our locations and imagine how researchers might play a role in evolving ethics and methodologies in order to seek to build dialogues across borders.” By foregrounding these issues through a decolonizing, feminist, DPAR approach, the hope in this project herein was to remain accountable to the voices, perspectives, and agency of co-researchers and their local communities in co-creating sustainable solutions when it comes to how bicycle-focused mobility justice interventions may possibility address SGBV.

Second, researchers trying to balance decolonial commitments with reflexive modes of analysis might expect a messy reality in this “between space” that operates at the intersection of the self/other nexus to which a decolonial feminist ethic may steer (Hayhurst, 2017). That is, a decolonial feminist approach provides an opportunity to pry open space for social transformation and justice, and these tenets should ultimately eclipse any perceived or tangible benefits of professional ‘benefits’ academics may seek (e.g., producing peer-reviewed publications, which then bolster competitive funding to produce the next grant application, award, etc.). For example, and in an attempt to address these power inequities, we have tried to prioritize the co-create key knowledge mobilization outputs from this project (e.g., documentary films, policy briefs, manuscripts and conference papers) *with* co-researchers, driven by reciprocity, mutuality, relationality and *their* politics and praxis (see Hayhurst et al., 2022, 2025b, 2025c; Hayhurst & Cobban, 2024; Nachman et al., 2023).

And yet, despite efforts to engage participants in a mutual learning process (for example, as Alessia stated, “we learned a new methodology, ‘photovoice,’ which now supports and strengthens our work by helping us document changes and share our stories with others,”) I would be remiss not to emphasize that digital PAR researchers using decolonial feminist approaches must ‘sit with’ the uncomfortable truths about the bald friction in this work. What’s more, the intersection of these issues with digital technology (e.g., GoPros) demands a careful ‘juggling act’ between ‘empowering’ marginalized voices and averting the reinforcement of heteropatriarchal capitalist, colonial structures.

Third, despite there being some benefits of using a decolonial feminist DPAR as a methodology, the complex interplay between digital tools like GoPros and the challenges of addressing SGBV in isolated rural environments impacted by climate change, presented several paradoxes in this study. Though digital technologies provided novel advocacy avenues for documenting bicycle safety, climate change and mobility justice; they also risked reinforcing structural issues such as racism, sexism, and surveillance-imbued safety measures. Indeed, as Alessia shared in a virtual meeting following data collection (July 25, 2023):

[The research] highlighted poor road conditions, evidenced through GIS-labeled photographs, as a barrier to development – an issue that has improved in recent years. We’ve been able to identify and promote the bicycle as a tool for development...helping girls exercise their right to move from one place to another, access primary and secondary education, and prevent violence (they use bicycles to get to school safely), take care of their health (especially during the pandemic), and protect the environment [...] Participating in these research projects has provided us with data that supports our applications for funding opportunities focused on girls’ development and empowerment.

Fourth, while the collaboratively developed decolonial feminist DPAR strategies documented unsafe conditions, they also placed an undue burden on the participants to prevent abuse by mapping out dangers and possibly deepened frustrations that these methodologies did not address structural issues, such as repairing bicycles or even being able to ensure new bicycles were readily available and donated.

However, as noted in the quote above by Alessia – and in collaboration with co-researchers – mapping strategies were used to shift the focus towards community and policy interventions that would amplify *their* voices, experiences, and perspectives in submitting solutions to address *their* safety. As Bianca noted, “I never ever even had a camera in my hands. And today you taught me how to take pictures. So, I’m going to also record a video. I’m going to go bicycle riding and use the camera [...] I think this will be a wonderful experience.” This reflects a broader discord within decolonial feminist DPAR, where the use of technology must be critically evaluated to ensure it supports, rather than undermines, the agency and narratives of those it aims to “empower.”

Overall, then, while digital technologies offer novel avenues for documenting and addressing issues related to bicycle safety, mobility, climate change and gender justice; at the same time, they also raise critical ethical and practical challenges that require meticulous consideration to avoid reinforcing the very issues they seek to combat. To this end, upholding relational accountabilities and relational mobilities encourages researchers to be reflexive about how their positionality and movement shape research encounters, while at the same time underlining how these very reflections are in service of strengthening an ethic of accountability to co-researchers and communities (see [Wilson & Mulrennan, 2016](#)). Taken together, my hope is that the decolonial feminist DPAR outlined in this paper might actively contribute to feminist transformation(s) that uphold(s) a more equitable, sustainable and just future.

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